Q. You have also started a special scheme for women's employment.
Yes, that's the fourth point. Economy is not about money but people and their activities. So, I have got a scheme done now where we are going to employ more than five lakh women this year through entrepreneurship. It will be an end-to-end approach; we are giving them seed money, 'anchor bank' interventions, products and marketing. All these measures will help people increase their per capita income and the prosperity of the state.

Q. While your welfare schemes have been lauded, there are issues about corruption, with contractors alleging that they had to pay 40 per cent commission. There have been graft charges against policemen too.
Very good question. First, that contractors' complaint was made just before I took charge. I was not the chief minister then. Second, I called these contractors and said, 'Give me some cases where 40 per cent has been paid and I will act.' They are unable to give any cases. They instead came with suggestions for system improvements, and I had them done immediately. I have also set up a high-level committee under a retired high court judge to look into the estimates of the work, especially tender commissions where the crux of the corruption is. Any project above Rs 50 crore will be scrutinised by this committee. In the police cases, we have also acted, including ordering a CID inquiry against a top policeman. We have never compromised our politics with corruption and we have raided both BJP and Congress people whenever needed.

Q. Your cabinet minister K.S. Eshwarappa had to resign because of allegations against him. What is the update?
The whole thing was enquired into in detail and the police have said there is no evidence of his role in it. It will now be scrutinised in the court, so that there is a judicial stamp to it.



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"ANTI-CONVERSION LAWS ARE NOT NEW IN THIS COUNTRY... WE ALL KNOW THAT CONVERSION BY ALLUREMENT AND FORCE IS NOT ALLOWED IN THE CONSTITUTION ITSELF"

Q. The other major issue is in terms of the rising communal tensions that have happened, whether the hijab controversy, the anti-conversion law that you have passed, or the issue of halal meat being served. Critics say that you are being more Hindutva than Hindutva itself.
I don't see the hijab issue as something that is political or communal. I see it as following the rules, and that approach has helped. Now everything is settled and there is no problem. Many of the minorities also agree that there should be a dress code. The whole problem is that the opinion of the silent majority is not taken into account and a few people that make noise are given a lot of space by the media. As far as the halal thing is concerned, that was made a rule by the Congress government earlier. So, we just followed it, as we did about the loudspeaker issue on which the Supreme Court had passed a ruling. I don't ascribe any colours to it and that approach has helped me. Now everybody is following the rule and there is peace.

Q. What was the provocation to pass the anti-conversion law in the assembly?
Anti-conversion laws are not new in this country; they have been there right from Mahatma Gandhi's time. We all know that conversion by allurement and force is not allowed in the Constitution itself. What the Constitution has said and what the earlier laws have said have just been reiterated. There will be no coercive activity, no illegality. We will go by the rule, you should also follow it.

Q. Is it because you joined the BJP only in 2008 that you are trying to prove your Hindutva credentials?
I am not worried about such drawing-room statements. I will put it in one